

we have an entire team here with a private sector background, they know exactly how investors are thinking,” he says. The agency is the first point of contact for MNCs. “The first thing they want is complete facilitation, complete hand-holding, which is what Invest India does for them, from location search to showing them the opportunity to getting all approvals,” says Bagla (*see interview for details*). The agency has a team dedicated to each government department, a team dedicated to states, and also countries. “They function in a matrix fashion,” he adds.

There is an interesting story of how Invest India engaged with Sweden-based Autoliv that makes safety airbags, among other auto components. The Philippines, Vietnam, and Thailand were the shortlisted destinations. The agency’s team, which got in touch with them after a roadshow, found that the company had earlier shortlisted a location in Chennai, but couldn’t proceed because of high costs. “We moved the selected land parcel 4.5 km away [from Chennai] to Cheyyar town and moved to a lease model. Now it is cheaper than anywhere else in the world, so the investment has moved to India,” smiles Bagla.

Similarly, in early 2000, French multinational Groupe PSA (now called Stellantis after its recent merger with Fiat Chrysler), known for brand Peugeot, exited India. By the mid-2000s, it was in a dire financial state, and began scouting for a globally competitive manufacturing destination. Invest India did some digging and found out that one of the board members was an Indian. It got in touch with him for a meeting with the board. The team flew down to Paris and made a strong pitch. It explained the market opportunity, favourable regulations, choices of

THE JOURNEY SO FAR

A central single-window clearance system is being widely awaited

2009

Invest India set up with a 51 per cent shareholding of Ficci and 49 per cent owned by the central government through DPIIT

2014

Make in India campaign launched

2015

New action plan, budget, salary structure approved by the Board of Directors and support from World Bank Group (WBG) begins

2016

Dedicated office space in New Delhi; Startup India campaign launched

2017

Private shareholding broadened with Ficci, CII and Nasscom owning 17 per cent each; state IPA capacity-building project launched in collaboration with WBG; expanded office space

2020

Work commences on the central single window system; Secretariat of Empowered Group of Secretaries and Project Development Cells established

SOURCE

WORLD BANK GROUP, WITH INPUTS FROM INVEST INDIA

states for a plant, and likely incentives. Finally, in 2017, PSA partnered with the CK Birla Group by taking over the ailing Hindustan Motors plant in south India. “That was one of our first big wins,” recalls an Invest India professional.

The agency is pulling off big projects despite having one of the lowest budgets among the world’s top 20 IPAs. But, Bagla and his squad, with an average age of 29, aren’t grumbling. Sample this: Pallavi Bishnoi, who looks after the Americas and Korea-plus desk, left her Goldman Sachs job to join Invest India. Meanwhile, Varda Taneja, who handles the Western Europe desk, has done a Masters from the London School of Economics.

Mahindra Group Chairman Anand Mahindra vouches for the team. “A young, professional and committed team has ushered in a ‘can do’ mindset. It is the team which seamlessly joins the dots and frames the picture. In effect, they have created a social ‘unicorn,’ a start-up, which in place of a billion-dollar valuation, impacts over a billion people!” Cadila Healthcare Chairman Pankaj R. Patel says it certainly goes to show that the institution has been able to look beyond the conventional framework of engaging and retaining talent and “offers the right milieu for rewarding careers”. DPIIT Secretary Anurag Jain says: “It [Invest India] has demonstrated effective and efficient utilisation of public resources and consistently delivered cost-efficient substantial outcomes.” All three sit on the agency’s 10-member board, which also includes Accenture’s Rekha Menon and Nasscom’s Debjani Ghosh. Jain is the Chairman.

Invest India is also helping start-ups through the Startup India mission, which it runs. For example, img, a start-up in the digital health